

Essay 1 Revision: A Diverging 'Bond'

"It is not as good as the original" is a phrase that marks the media industry today. This loss of the essence of the original version of a form of media in translation can be attributed to everything from Greek myths to the Harry Potter series. However, inherent to translation is change and modernization, and can that be beneficial in some capacities?

The world-renowned fictional action hero James Bond has been adapted into countless forms of media. However, his adaptation across one particular form of media – television – has produced over 27 movies featuring 6 different actors since 1962. While each actor represents this prototypical masculine action hero who attempts mind-bending stunts and somehow pulls them off effortlessly, they are each producing a translated version – their own interpretation – of this archetype, consciously or subconsciously, in the process. My examination of two particular Bond heroes – Sean Connery and Daniel Craig – will attempt to assess the translation of the prototypical 'James Bond' across generations through characteristics, accuracy to the role, and audience appeal.

The quintessential James Bond is considered to be a charming gun-wielding womanizer who can jump off a 50 foot cliff and land perfectly. The humanized form of this role is Sean Connery, who marked the 1960s with a sort of masculine dream. One particular scene that encapsulates his womanizing nature is in *Thunderball* (1965), when Bond forces himself on a woman without consent, and continues to kiss her despite her repeated refusal. This establishes Bond as a dominant male, who can control women. In marked contrast, Daniel Craig produces an emotionally vulnerable character diverting from the somewhat 'classic' role created by Connery and carried out by the other Bond heroes. In the 2012 Bond film *Casino Royale*, Craig's Bond falls in love with heroine Vesper Lynd and imagines leaving the secret service to start a life with

her. However, this is tragically ruined as she proves a traitor and commits suicide. While Bond moves on from this, it is the first time he is portrayed as emotional and vulnerable, and Lynd asserts a sort of ‘control’ over *him* instead. His pain is further enhanced by the death of ‘M’, a modern take on Bond’s secretary Moneypenny, who was the subject of flirtatious jabs in older films. Craig transforms Bond from an emotionless womanizer to a man that has fallen in love. In this translation, the cultural establishment of frivolous ‘Bond girls’ that are objects for James Bond is removed because he, who is supposedly devoid of emotion, feels love and grief—two of the strongest emotions a human is capable of feeling.

In this process of ‘carrying across’, James Bond has been humanized in this unfiltered portrayal of his emotional affectations, creating a ‘feminine’ dimension to his role. The lighthearted but serious Bond crafted in Ian Fleming’s original novel and carried by Sean Connery is left behind. While successive James Bond actors, like Roger Moore and Pierce Brosnan, were versions of this macho womanizer adding small embellishments like humor to the role, Craig created a new person altogether through the raw depth assumed by this character. In evaluating the effectiveness of the translation of the original Bond crafted by Connery to Craig’s emotional adaptation, one can argue that the traditional role of James Bond in the film industry has been lost. However, the argument of whether the ‘original’ version of a role is necessarily the most socially acceptable portrayal comes into question.

In terms of the effect of the change in Bond from the role of Connery to Craig, it signifies a change in the attitudes of the public. This was significant in the making of Craig’s Bond, as the franchise was in need of a shift in the narrative of James Bond in order to appeal to the modern audience. This is because quintessential masculine qualities of rage, strength, and control have become outdated in their reception by the public. Instead, heroes with an emotional backstory

that shapes their characters, giving them a certain level of depth as people, are more readily accepted in the public sphere today. Further, as the change of traditional gender roles in society has altered the narrative for roles occupied by men and women, this sociological change must also be attributed to the role of James Bond.

Many Greek Myths tell sexist tales, which are hardly altered in viewpoint from their original form. The translation from Connery to Craig, however, successfully takes away from the traditionally misogynistic notion associated with James Bond, making him acceptable in the modern public sphere. Equipping Bond with the qualities of love and grief give a humanized depth to his character. The art of translation, or ‘carrying across’ in all capacities, in its most powerful form can thus be defined as a change to suit a shift in times, and a push to diversify the reach of an existing role in its reception from a broader audience. The emotionalization of Bond allowed for his character to resonate with men and women alike, and further depict a man that had emotions, altering the narrative of a misogynistic superhero. However, does this take away from what Bond represents in his truest form? This is a question yet to be reckoned with, as change is inevitable in society, and the only attempt to break down discrimination. Thus, the translation of Bond from Connery to Craig can be attributed to a change in time, and the gradual result of modernization of public opinion, essentially making it welcome in my perspective.

Metacognition:

In the process of revising my essay, I viewed the feedback that was given to me, which was primarily to expand my explanation of the effect that the translation of Bond signifies, and what this depicts about the process of translation in general. Then, I reread my essay, and understood the points where I should expand further. For example, in my concluding paragraph, I

had originally discussed only the effect of the translation of James Bond. However, as the prompt asks us to further probe into how this specific example of translation can direct us further into an understanding of the process of translation in general, I needed to include analysis that extrapolated this example into the larger public sphere. Hence, my discussion of translation in all capacities being defined as a change to suit shift in time and a diversification of the reach of an existing role more clearly examines the broader context of this example of translation. Further, in my extrapolation of this example to a broader context, I also examined the impact of sociological changes on the franchise, “the change of traditional gender roles in society has altered the narrative for roles occupied by men and women” (2). This further helped solidify the significance of the shift from Connery to Craig because of its solidification of sociological shifts that I only touched on in my reexamination of this analysis. The furthering of my explanatory analysis depicts the broader implications of my original example. This reflects changes from my initially rigid analysis of just the specific topic. I feel that over the course of the semester, I have improved in going deeper into my analysis rather than wider, through a thorough examination of specific examples and their broader implications as opposed to a wide range of loosely related examples without proper understanding.

New Reflection:

Of the Greek myths we studied this past semester, I most enjoyed the translation of *Lysistrata*. Sarah Ruden’s translation of this work uses contemporary language to cater the play to a modern audience. Additionally, the informal language used among regular, everyday characters allowed the theme of the story to be accessible to a wider audience base. This was

effective because a work of translation in its most powerful form is adapted to suit a diverse audience and modern culture.

This adaptation has been successful in catering to a modern audience through its use of everyday slang. For example, the language used in the phrase “You *are* a clever thang. Fine all around!” (line 180) could belong to a modern-day conversation. The term “fine” in a contemporary context is a slang term used to mean attractive. It is interesting, as such, that Ruden would deliberately choose to use this word in her translation. This depicts the everyday context within which the play takes place, and allows the audience to establish a sense of familiarity with the character Lysistrata. Additionally, the phrase “Fine all around” is flirtatious in nature, and is used in a conversation among women. Flirtatious behavior is itself outspoken within Greek literature, and the use of this outspoken behavior among women is further uncommon. Due to this, the play *Lysistrata* establishes a familiarity with modern audiences in its use of informal language and through the outspoken nature of its women.

In understanding the outspoken nature of women in this Greek play, the directness of women in their responses to men must be examined. In line 374, the Men’s Chorus Leader argues with the Women’s Chorus Leader about their sex strike. In response to the Male Leader’s insults and demands, the Female Leader replies, “Why not? I’m not a slave” (376). This response is immediate and assertive, and this line of speaking is used throughout the argument between the man and woman. As Greece was originally a patriarchal society, it was rare to see women retorting back to their male counterparts, and Ruden’s adaptation of this altercation allows readers to see the conviction that was held by the women participating in the sex strike that allowed them the power to speak back to men with such assertion and authority. Additionally, the decisiveness with which Lysistrata herself speaks is clear. When she explains to the women of

Athens that the sex strike will be effective in getting the men to stop fighting in the war, she explains that “They’ll give up—you’ll see / How fast. No husband’s going to like to screw / Unless he knows his woman likes it too.” (line 164-166). This line explicitly places power in the hands of the women as powerful entities in their husbands’ lives. Lysistrata is so clear in her thoughts about the success of this strike that she assures the women by saying, “they’ll give up—you’ll see”, that they will come out strong and stop the men from their plunder. This tone of assurance and defiance of the patriarchal norms further equips this translation with a contemporary spin in contrast to the male-centric roles of other Greek myths.